



Ethical Hacking 101 - Resources You Can Use

Tools, discussion groups & virtual systems

Insecure.org:

<http://www.insecure.org/>

Pull The Plug:

www.pulltheplug.org

Whoppix Penetration Testing

Toolkit:

<http://www.whoppix.net/>

The PacketStorm IP Network

Emulators:

<http://www.packetstorm.com/>

K-OTik Security (French):

<http://www.k-otik.com/>

Phrack (Hacker E-zine):

<http://www.phrack.org/>

Hacker's Lab:

<http://www.hackerslab.org/>

Honeypot Project (Online honeypot deployment):

<http://www.honeynet.org/>

Crackmes.de (Challenges for reversers, newbies, white hats and black hats):

<http://www.crackmes.de/>

Eric S Raymond's homepage:

<http://www.catb.org/~esr>

Carnegie Mellon Software

Engineering Institute:

<http://www.cert.org>

The SANS (SysAdmin, Audit,

Network, Security) Institute:

<http://www.sans.org>

Ethical Hacker's Association (India):

<http://www.netmonastery.com/eha/eah.htm>



Conferences

DEFCON:

<http://www.defcon.org/>

Black Hat conference:

<http://www.blackhat.com>

COMDEX:

<http://www.comdex.com/>

moving out to start his own security firm, Net Monastery. He also founded the EHA (Ethical Hackers' Association) "to increase awareness about security in the tech community and to educate programmers on measures to avoid mistakes that attract bugs or cause vulnerabilities."

Says Das Gupta, "Hacking is more about instinct than hardcore programming skills. You have to understand network architecture and be adept with hacking tools. But to be an ethical hacker, one has to build trust... which takes time to establish but can be lost easily."

KK Mookhey, a Certified Information Systems Auditor (CISA) with over four years of security

experience, agrees. "The gains are low in malicious hacking, and really, it makes stupid business sense to cross that line," he says.

Both swear by the Code of Vulnerability Disclosure—inform the vendor first on discovering a vulnerability, ask for a time period and assurance that the flaw will be fixed. "Else, you threaten to go public," says KK, whose team has discovered vulnerabilities in software from vendors like Microsoft, Oracle, Nortel and Macromedia.

Das Gupta and KK represent the growing breed of young security professionals in India. In the recent past, India has seen a host of teenage prodigies emerge in the security space. Sixteen-year-old Namit Merchant, for example, is the youngest ever CISSP—a widely-recognised certification, which requires a minimum of three years of full-time professional computer security experience, prior to taking the test.

Ankit Fadia, a teen prodigy, was just 16 when he authored *The Unofficial Guide to Ethical Hacking*. A Computer Security and Digital Intelligence Consultant, he is now one of the best-known ethical hackers in India.

The S-Word

Security threats for companies (SMBs and enterprises) have gained prominence in the last few decades. With more and more governments and companies jumping onto the 'world wide web' bandwagon, seamless connectivity (through Virtual Private Networks, for example) across branches is crucial for efficient functioning of a business network.

Today, viruses and worms proliferate on the Web within a matter of minutes. Not only do networks and security systems need to react instantaneously, security companies also need to develop more complex and stable solutions. SMBs usually employ a team comprising a Systems Administrator and security experts to monitor networks, 24x7.

Some of the best-known names in the security industry include MIEL e-Security, Mahindra SSG, SecureSynergy, HCL Comnet, IT Secure, and Cisco Systems. Security firms offer services such as penetration testing, vulnerability assessments, security audits, consulting and education. Many security companies also develop security assessment and intrusion-detection tools, and engage in security-related research.

Careers In Hacking

Says Jagdish Mahapatra, business development manager, Cisco Systems, India and SAARC, "Organisations are beginning to realise that security has to be top priority on their IT investment budget. It's the level of protection that causes the dilemma. Most SMBs have a security policy in place, but these have to be updated on a regular basis based on the company's needs, the current environment and threats."

Security firms employ 'certified ethical hackers' to perform audits as well as develop security tools. But are they wary of hackers? "Anyone who can wreak havoc is a useful tool for a security company. Especially while building a security system for a network, hackers come in handy—they come up with different ways of penetrating the network," says Mahapatra.

Security engineer Kartikeya Puri of MIEL eSecurity, says, "Though security companies develop exploits, some organisations prefer just random audits—by running tools like Nessus, a vulnerability scanner—to generate reports. You don't really need to be a hacker for that! Even my ten-year old brother can run that tool! Secu-

